

Author's Craft: Compare the Choices

Name: _____

Class: _____

Date: _____

Answer in your book. Today: why one piece of writing works better than another, marked against the scheme.

The craft frame

The writer ___ (the choice, quoted) so that the reader ___ (feels or thinks), because ___ (how it does that).

2-mark scheme

2 = the choice + a quote + HOW it affects the reader.

1 = names an effect with no how ("it creates suspense").

Part A: Do Now (4 min)

A1 The old car coughed twice and died at the traffic lights.

Name the device and explain its effect.

A2 "The leg of the table" and "her laugh was a door slamming". Which one is a dead metaphor, and why can't you explain its effect?

Part B: Ruin It! (pairs, 10 min)

Each opening below works. Your job: wreck it. Rewrite it so it is as boring as possible, then name exactly what you removed.

Swap with your partner: can they spot what is missing?

1 The last thing I expected to find in my sandwich was a key.
2 Mum smiled at the doctor, thanked him twice, and cried the whole way home.

3 Nobody remembered the new girl's name. By Friday, nobody would ever forget it.
4 The house had one rule: never open the green door. I opened it on a Tuesday.

Example ruin: "I found a key in my sandwich. It was strange." Removed: the surprise, and holding back the key until the last word.

Part C: On your own (9 marks)

Opening A

It was a stormy night. Jack was scared because he was home alone and the power had gone out. He decided to go to bed.

Opening B

The lights went out at 9:14. Jack counted the seconds between the flash and the bang, the way Dad had taught him. Seven. Then four. Then none at all.

C1 Which opening hooks the reader better? [1]

C2 How does the writer of Opening B build tension? Refer to two choices. [2]

C3 Opening A tells us Jack is "scared". How does Opening B show it instead? [2]

C4 Why does Opening B end with "Then none at all." [2]

C5 From a school newsletter: "Imagine a school with no playground. Now stop imagining: it is ours."

Why does the writer begin with "Imagine", then tell us to stop? [2]

Part D: Swap and mark (7 min)

Swap books. Mark your partner's C2 and C4 out of 2 with the scheme at the top. Under each, write one line: "To get 2 you needed ..."

Part E: Exit Ticket (on your own, 2 marks)

E Grandma's house was the same as always. The clock still ticked. The kettle still sang. Her chair was empty.

Why does the writer list the things that are "still" the same before the last sentence?